IIT Bhilai Innovation and Technology Foundation
IIT Bhilai Permanent campus, Kutelabhata, Khapri, District- Durg, Chhattisgarh - 491002
CIN: U80902CT2021NPL011186 | PAN: AAFCI9961E | TAN: JBPI01305D
Website: https://www.ibitf.co.in/ | Email: tih@iitbhilai.ac.in

Call for Proposals

Under Tribal Area Sub Plan 2026

IIT Bhilai Innovation and Technology Foundation

Category 'A' - Technology Innovation Hub (TIH) under the National Mission of Interdisciplinary Cyber-Physical Systems (NM-ICPS), Executed by the Department of Science and Technology (DST), Government of India (GoI)

Introduction

The IIT Bhilai Innovation and Technology Foundation (IBITF) is a Section-8 not-for-profit company, established under the National Mission on Interdisciplinary Cyber-Physical Systems (NM-ICPS) of the Department of Science and Technology (DST), Government of India. IBITF focuses on the development and deployment of projects in the Fintech domain, identifying impactful solutions that leverage emerging technologies such as blockchain, IoT, AI/ML, and e-payments. And application of these technologies across other sectors, including agritech, HealthTech, Energy, Communication, Industry 4.0, Judiciary, Supply chain, Logistics, etc.

IBITF has been recognised as a Category-A Hub based on its performance and outcomes since its inception. IBITF provides a vibrant ecosystem that connects startups, researchers, academia, industry, and government stakeholders. Through funding support, incubation facilities, expert mentorship, and market access, IBITF empowers innovators to transform ideas into scalable, impactful solutions that address real-world challenges and contribute to India's growth as a global innovation leader. The Foundation plays a pivotal role in translating deep-tech research into market-ready products and solutions, as well as in nurturing startups, innovation, and entrepreneurship, particularly those from Tier II/III cities and remote rural and tribal regions.

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About the Call for Proposal

The IIT Bhilai Innovation and Technology Foundation (IBITF) invites proposals under the Tribal Area Sub-Plan (TSP) scheme, designed to nurture tribal-centric/tribal-led innovation, entrepreneurship, and technology commercialization. The CFP is designed to support the rapid productization, deployment, and commercialization of technology-driven solutions, beneficial for the ST community at large, under the core thematic areas of IBITF, including Fintech applications, Agritech, HealthTech, Transport, Energy, and others. The scheme encourages collaboration among startups, industry, and academia, while providing financial assistance, expert mentorship, and access to a national network of stakeholders.

The Tribal Area Sub-Plan (TSP) Scheme is to significantly enhance the livelihoods, improve income generation opportunities, and provide value addition to the locally sourced products for the Scheduled Tribe (ST) communities by intervention of technology-based solutions. This initiative aims to address the specific challenges faced by these communities through the strategic deployment of cutting-edge technologies such as Artificial Intelligence/Machine Learning (AI/ML), Internet of Things (IoT), Blockchain, and E-Payments, with a primary emphasis on applying these technologies to other sectors like FinTech, AgricTech, HealthTech, Transport, Energy, etc.

The scheme aims to bridge development gaps by promoting innovation, skill development, and technology-based interventions tailored to the specific needs of tribal communities, thereby enhancing the efficiency of their livelihood systems. It focuses on creating sustainable livelihood opportunities through local resource management, capacity building, and entrepreneurship promotion.

In the previous cohort of the scheme, IBITF supported 61 projects under the TSP scheme. Of these, 36 projects were implemented across the North-Eastern states, while 20 projects were supported in Chhattisgarh. The remaining projects were distributed across other regions of the country. Several startups incubated under the scheme gained national-level visibility and recognition through their participation in national and DST-led events and workshops, including TIPS 7.0 and Startup Mahakumbh, reflecting the program’s effectiveness in nurturing high-potential ventures.

The Tribal Area Sub Plan (TSP) initiative represents a structured, technology-driven national effort to address the socio-economic challenges of Scheduled Tribe–dominated regions through deep-tech innovation, entrepreneurship, and capacity building through 61 projects across multiple states, cutting across FinTech, AgriTech, and HealthTech domains. These projects are not isolated pilots; they are anchored in extensive on-ground stakeholder consultations, multi-state workshops, and formal collaborations with universities, medical institutions, and government bodies. The initiative has already resulted in over 23 women entrepreneurs, more than 300+ direct jobs, and training of over 15,000 individuals, reflecting a strong blend of scientific development with livelihood-oriented outcomes.

Under the TSP framework, the Hub has supported solutions ranging from AI-enabled healthcare delivery platforms, m-health systems, smart emergency response tools, and medical data analytics, to blockchain-based agricultural supply chains, multilingual fintech platforms, smart mobility systems, precision agriculture, and sustainable urban services. Several projects have progressed to higher Technology Readiness Levels, with operational pilots, deployed platforms, and proof-of-concept implementations in areas such as smart parking, public health service delivery, agricultural marketplaces, indigenous knowledge digitization, and tribal artisan empowerment. These deployments demonstrate the programme's shift from concept development to field-validated, scalable digital infrastructure tailored for remote and underserved regions.

Overall, the TSP scheme under IBITF has created a robust innovation-to-impact pipeline - from problem discovery in tribal geographies to funded research, startup formation, field pilots, and ecosystem partnerships. Its outcomes reflect not only technological advancement but also institutional capacity building, entrepreneurship development, regional job creation, and technology adoption in governance, healthcare, agriculture, and livelihoods. The initiative positions IIT Bhilai and IBITF as a national

anchor for translating deep technologies into inclusive, deployable solutions that can be replicated across tribal and aspirational regions of India.

IBITF is also working in collaboration with the Technology Innovation Hubs (TIHs) of IIT Bombay (https://tihiitb.org/) and IIT Indore (https://drishticps.org/) in the domains of HealthTech and AgriTech, respectively, with a focus on developing and deploying technology-driven solutions for tribal and underserved communities.

For more details, please visit our website: https://www.ibitf.co.in/

Eligibility

The Principal Investigator/Project Director/CEO/Head of the project/Institution/Startup/Organization related to the project/program/scheme belongs to the ST category.

Or

Above 50% of project/program/scheme beneficiaries belong to the ST community.

Applications are invited under following two categories:-

1. **Academic Institutions:**

- Government Academic Institutions (Central and State Government), etc., Private Academic Institutions (Universities/ Colleges/ Institutions and Government Aided Colleges recognized or regulated by UGC/AICTE/MCI/DCI/PCI etc.) – would be considered and are encouraged to apply online. (Applicable for faculty members in permanent positions holding Academicians, Scientists, Technologists, and other Practicing Researchers affiliated to recognized academic research institutions and registered scientific societies, State S&T Councils, etc.)

2. **Startups/Industry**

- Startups recognized by DPIIT, including those led by academic institutions, faculty, students, and researchers, are eligible to apply. Registered companies (MSMEs or Enterprises) with prior experience in product development or R&D are also eligible.
- Startups employing or planning to leverage emerging technologies such as blockchain, IoT, AI/ML, and e-payments in sectors including AgriTech, HealthTech, Transport, Energy, etc., are invited to present their products or services. IBITF may provide relevant support to qualified startups and solutions.

Note: Preference will be given to:

1. **Proposals supported by government agencies, startups, or industry partners through financial and infrastructural assistance.**

2. **IBITF is working in collaboration with the IIT Bombay-led Technology Innovation Hub in AgriTech and the Technology Innovation Hub of IIT Indore in MedTech. Preference may be given to proposals specifically addressing the solutions for Bastar and Dantewada regions, particularly in the domains of AgriTech and MedTech.**

3. **Proposals that add value to operational projects under the Tribal Area Sub Plan (TSP) Scheme of IBITF through product enhancement, deployment, or scale-up within 6–12 months, etc. (Connect tih@iitbhilai.ac.in for further information on projects incharge contacts etc)**
4. **Proposals demonstrating clear pathways for deployment and commercialization, including defined market readiness and revenue potential.**
5. **Projects are expected to deliver a working Prototype or Minimum Viable Product (MVP) within 6-8 months, followed by go-to-market readiness and a comprehensive business plan within 12 months (only TRL>4 proposals can be considered).**

6. **IP and Revenue Sharing: Governed through a mutually agreed-upon agreement between the Startup and IBITF, based on IP contributions, investment, and commercialization**

Details of the ongoing projects funded by IBITF under the Tribal Area Sub Plan Scheme are listed below:

https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/15VNt9PKHuNiZ7ULY0WzpYlViNnFWkmfmpH5eS6n9I2Q/edit?usp=sharing

If the collaborating startup/industry requires additional information or discussion with the project lead, IBITF can facilitate this. Email: tih@iitbhilai.ac.in

Evaluation Criteria (All Categories)

The evaluation of proposals submitted will be based on a comprehensive review of key parameters aligned with IBITF's strategic objectives. Proposals must demonstrate strong technical innovation and novelty, showcasing the ability to address critical challenges through transformative technology-based solutions. Particular emphasis will be placed on market fit and commercial viability, ensuring that the proposed solution has a well-defined target audience, value proposition, and a feasible go-to-market strategy.

The strength of the project team, including the experience and technical expertise of the Principal Investigator (PI), Co-Investigators, startup, industry, and collaborating partners, will also play a critical role in the assessment process. In addition, IBITF places importance on the intellectual property (IP) potential of the proposal and its alignment with the required Technology Readiness Level (TRL), which should ideally be TRL-4 or higher for proposals closer to deployment.

Budget justification, including a realistic cost estimate and clarity on the proposed co-funding mechanism, will be thoroughly scrutinized to ensure optimal resource utilization and alignment with project goals. Following the internal evaluation, which will verify whether the proposal aligns with

IBITF's mandated technology domains, IBITF will establish a Project Review Committee. This committee will conduct a three-stage evaluation process.

- **Stage 01 -** Technical evaluation of the proposed solution.
- **Stage 02 -** Commercial evaluation and viability of the project.
- **Stage 03 -** Business evaluation of the participating organizations/entities.
- **Stage 04-** The final approval shall only be accorded to the proposals obtaining legal and compliances clearance.

It should be noted that the relative emphasis on these parameters may vary depending on the nature of the proposal. The parameters that will support the approval of a project proposal by the IBITF project review committee may include (but are not limited to) market viability, proposed co-funding mechanism, team strength, IP potential, and the strength of research credentials.

Co-Funding

Proposals with co-investment commitments will be given preference.

Project Duration

All proposals should have an initial duration of 6 to 12 months, extendable up to 1 year based on performance review and recommendation by the IBITF Project Review Committee. Meeting milestones and Key Performance Indicators may provide leverage for future funding, as well as when a new cohort call is made.

Funding and Disbursement

1. The extent of financial support from IBITF shall be contingent upon factors such as the availability of funds from the funding agency, the technical feasibility and novelty of the proposal, its commercial viability, alignment with industry/government requirements, and the level of engagement from other stakeholders associated with the proposal.
2. Performance based further funding support can be considered based on availability of funds.

The fund disbursement and project execution framework shall be communicated to the proposing entities upon successful completion of the evaluation process. The fund would be available against equity (iSAFE, CCSP, or other financial instruments could be considered), grant, loan or combination of all.

The framework will provide an overview of the fund disbursement process, financial management norms, and the project execution structure, along with the roles and responsibilities of the collaborating partners.

Revenue Sharing Structure (Indicative)

The revenue-sharing framework for projects funded under this Call for Proposal will be formalized between IBITF and the collaborating partner(s) through a mutually agreed agreement, executed on a case-by-case basis. The terms and conditions specified in the agreement shall govern the arrangement.

Application Process

Deadline for Proposal Submission: 31 October 2026.

All proposals must be submitted via the Accubate Platform Link (given below).

**Please note that all annexures provided below should be attached to the submitted proposal.*

A copy of the submitted applications shall be emailed to tih@iitbhilai.ac.in

Link for Accubate Platform to apply:-https://tihiitbhilai.accubate.app/ext/form/24422/1/apply

Contact

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Proposal Submission Format

IIT Bhilai Innovation and Technology Foundation (IBITF)

A Technology Innovation Hub under NM-ICPS, DST, Government of India

1. **Choose Application Category:-**

   ☐ Academic Institution

   ☐ Startup/Industry

2. **Title of the Proposal**

3. **Thematic Area**

   Select the core area under which your project lies:

   ☐ AI/ML

   ☐ Blockchain

   ☐ IoT

   ☐ E-Payments System

   ☐ Agritech

   ☐ Healthtech

   ☐ Logistics

   ☐ Communication

   ☐ supply chain

   ☐ Industry 4.0

   ☐ Judiciary

   ☐ Energy

   ☐ Others (Please specify):

4. **Proposed Duration of the Project**

   ☐ 6 Months

   ☐ 9 Months

   ☐ 12 Months

   (Extendable based on performance)

5. **Aims, Objectives, and Problem Statement (Max. 500 words)**

   a. Background and Rationale

   b. Targeted Beneficiaries

   c. Specific problems to be addressed and expected outcomes

   d. Progress so far

   e. Proposed Outcome for the customer

6. **Principal Investigator (PI) Details (for Academic institutions, faculty, students, and researchers only)**

   a. Name:

   b. Designation:

   c. Department:

   d. Institution:

   e. Official Address:

   f. Email:

   g. Mobile Number:

   h. Category (ST/SC/OBC/General):

   i. Male/Female:

7. **Co-Principal Investigator(s) (for Academic institutions, faculty, students, and researchers only) [if any] (Repeat this section for each Co-PI)**

   a. Name:

b. Designation

c. Department:

d. Institution:

e. Official Address:

f. Email:

g. Mobile Number:

h. Category (ST/SC/OBC/General):

i. Male/Female:

8.Startup / Industry Partner Details (If applicable)

a. Name of the Company:

b. Type:

☐ DPIIT Registered Startup

☐ MSME/SME

☐ Large Enterprise

☐ Any other (please specify)

c. Company Incorporation Details:

i. CIN

ii. TAN

iii. PAN

d. Company Age:

i. Months -

ii. Years -

e. Founder(s) / CEO/Head of organization:

f. Address:

g. Email:

h. Phone:

i. Website (if any):

j. DPIIT Recognition Number (for startups)

9.Government Collaboration Details (If applicable)

a. Name of the Ministry / Department (Central/State):

b. Type of Support:

☐ Financial

☐ Infrastructure

c. Division / Wing:

d. Nodal Officer Details

i. Name:

ii. Designation:

iii. Department:

iv. Official Address:

v. Email:

vi. Mobile Number:

vii. Category (ST/SC/OBC/General):

viii. Male/Female:

10.Business Plan and Co-Funding Details

a. Summary of business goals and partnership structure

b. Funding contribution by startup/industry partner (preferred at least 10% of overall cost of project) and absolute terms

11. Novelty and Innovation (Max. 250 words)

a. How is the proposed solution distinct from current methods?

b. What innovative elements or IP does it involve?

12.Revenue and Commercialization Model (Max. 500 words)

a. Product/Service description

b. Go-to-market strategy

c. Pricing, revenue generation, and scalability plan

13.Patents, Publications, and Prototypes Developed (if any)

List all relevant IPs, published work, and prototypes. Mention status (granted/filed/under dev).

14.Deliverables

a. Projected Revenue and Expenditure Plan
b. Expected Publications / Technologies / IPRs
c. Jobs to be created and future hiring roadmap

15.Gantt Chart with Quarterly Milestones and TRL Progression

a. Indicate TRL at the start and expected TRL after each quarter
b. Expected TRL at project end (minimum TRL-7)

16.Budget Estimate and Contribution Summary (INR)

Head	6 Months Expences	Next 6 Months Expences	Industry/Startup Financial Support	IBITF Fund Requested
Equipment				
Travel				
Manpower				
Contingencies				
Total				

Note: All budget estimates should include justification.

17.Expertise and Infrastructure

a. Brief profile of PI and Co-PIs
b. Co-Funding Details:
    i. Partner Name:
    ii. Contribution Amount:
    iii. Form (cash/kind):
    iv. Timeline of Contribution:
c. Facilities available with the host institute/startup/industry for execution

18. Category-Specific Requirements-Startup or Industry Collaborating with IBITF-funded Project (Ongoing under TSP Scheme)

a. Project Alignment Note (max 500 words) explaining fit with existing IBITF-funded projects.
b. Enhancement Plan & Integration Roadmap (max 500 words) for building upon the existing project.
c. Have you discussed with PI the IBITF funded project(ongoing) regarding the alignment with the proposal (Yes/No) ?

Please note that all annexures provided below should be attached to the submitted proposal.

ANNEXURES

Annexure-1

CERTIFICATE FROM THE INVESTIGATOR

(On official letterhead)

PROPOSAL Title:

Name(s) of the PI's and Co-PI's:

1. I/We agree to abide by the terms and conditions of the grant received from IBITF.
2. I/We did not submit this or a similar project proposal elsewhere for financial support.
3. I/We agree to open a start-up company to execute the project.
4. I/We undertake to submit progress reports, Statement of Expenditure (SE)/ accounts, Utilization Certificates (UC), etc. covering up to 31st March every year till the completion of the project as prescribed by DST.

Date: **Signature of PI/PIs**

Place:

Date: **Signature of Co-PIs**

Place

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Annexure-2

ENDORSEMENT FROM THE HEAD OF THE INSTITUTION

(On official letterhead)

PROPOSAL TITLE:

Name(s) of the PI's and Co-PI's:

It is certified that the Institute welcomes the participation of the above as the Principal Investigator(s) and/or Co-PI(s) for the project.

1. Certified that the equipment, other basic facilities, and other administrative and accounting facilities, as per the terms and conditions of the grant, will be extended to the investigator throughout the project. In case of PI/Co-PI leaving the institution or proceeding on a long leave during the project period, prior permission will be sought from IBITF before relieving/sanctioning.

2. Certified that the investigators can open a start-up company (unconditionally) to execute the project, per the institute's policy.

3. Institute assumes the project's financial and other management responsibilities, including timely submission of Progress Reports, UCs, and SEs, and facilitates external audits if required.

Name of the Head of Institution

Signature with stamp

Date

Place:

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Annexure-3

Endorsement From the PI to meet either/both of the conditions for projects under the Tribal Area Sub Plan (TSP) guidelines.

ST Caste Certificate of The Principal Investigator/ Project Director/CEO/Head of the project/Institution/Startup/Organization related to the project/program/scheme belonging to the ST category should be included as Annexure 3.

Or

The PI should provide relevant information and endorsement to ensure that above 50% of project/program/scheme beneficiaries belong to the ST community.

Date: **Signature of PI/PIs**

Place:

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Annexure-4

PROFORMA FOR BIO-DATA

1. **Name:**
2. **Designation:**
3. **Department:**
4. **Institution:**
5. **Contact Number**
6. **Email:**
7. **Date of Birth:**
8. **Gender:**
9. **Academic Qualification: (Undergraduate Onwards)**

S.No.	Degree	Year	Subject	University/Institution	% of Marks

10. **Work Experience (in chronological order)**

S.No.	Position held	Institution	From	To	Pay Scale

11. Professional Recognition/ Award/ Prize/ Certificate/ Fellowship received by the member

S.No.	Name of Award	Awarding Agency	Year

12. Publications (List of papers published in SCI Journals, in year-wise descending order)

S.No.	Authors	Title	Journal	Volume	Page	Year

13. Detail of Patents

S.No.	Patent Title	Name of Applicant(s)	Patent No.	Award Date	Agency/ Country	Status

14. Books/Reports/Chapters/General articles etc.

S.No.	Title	Publisher	Year of Publication

15. List of Projects implemented

15.1 Details of Projects in progress

S.No.	Title	Cost in Lakh	Duration	Role(PI/Co-PI)	Agency

15.2 Details of Projects completed

S.No.	Title	Cost in Lakh	Duration	Role(PI/Co-PI)	Agency

16. Mode and extent of Funding: The funds are from the Department of Science and Technology, Government of India, under the National Mission on Interdisciplinary Cyber-Physical Systems (NM-ICPS) for the Technology Innovation Hub (FINTECH) at IIT Bhilai. Thus, the commitment of the funds from IBITF is subject to the grants received from the funding organization, i.e., DST, Govt. of India. The actual disbursement of funds by IBITF would be based on reimbursement of actual expenditure against the bills and the advance (if availed of any, needs to be settled within one month of the release).

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Terms and Conditions

The financial support is for the specific project as approved by IIT Bhilai Innovation And Technology Foundation (IBITF) and shall be subject to the conditions listed below. The PI/Start-up shall give an undertaking that they agree to be governed by these conditions:

1. The amount shall be i) spent for the project within the specified time; and ii) Any portion of the grant, which is not ultimately required for expenditure for the approved purposes, shall be duly surrendered to IBITF.

2. The PI/Start-up shall maintain an audited record as a register in the prescribed proforma for permanent, semi-permanent assets acquired solely or mainly out of an IBITF grant;

3. The assets referred to in (2) above will be the property of IBITF and should not, without prior sanction of IBITF, be disposed of or encumbered or utilized for the proposes other than those for which the grant has been sanctioned;

4. Should PI/Start-up cease to exist at any time, such assets, etc., shall revert to IBITF;

5. The PI/Start-up shall render progress-cum-achievement reports at intervals of not Exceeding three months on the progress made on all aspects of the project, including expenditure incurred on various approved items during the period;

6. The utilization of grants for the intended purposes will be looked into by the Auditor of IBITF according to the directives issued by the DST Government of India;

7. IBITF or its nominee(s) will have the right of access to the books and accounts of The PI/Start-up for which a reasonable prior notice would be given;

8. PI/Start-up should not retain the sale proceeds of prototypes, etc., fabricated due to the project's development arising directly from funds granted by the IBITF. The PI/Start-up should return to IBITF funds thus generated;

9. The Intellectual property and its associated rights shall be owned jointly by the PI/Start-up and IBITF. Both parties may share any royalties or other benefits generated by licensing such joint IP under mutually agreed terms on a case-to-case basis. The PI/Start-up is expected to hive off a start-up to deploy the system. In such a case, the IP could be transferred to the start-up;

10. IBITF shall appoint a Project Review and Steering Group (PRSG) comprising representatives from IBITF and other experts; PRSG will periodically monitor the project in all respects, including technical and financial;

11. In case of any dispute on any matter related to the project during its implementation, the decision of the IBITF shall be final and binding on the proposal originating industry/industry consortium and PI/Start-up;

12. A representative of IBITF could be a member of the Board of Directors of the Start-up.